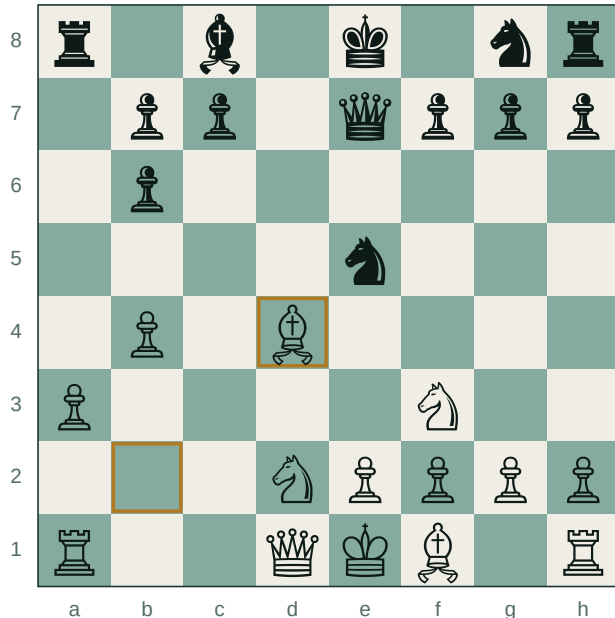


# Smothered mates: Black, move 11

Smothered mates

Black to move



Previous move: 11.Bxd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

**WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST**

**11...Nd3#**

**11...Nd3#** Mate: knight on d3 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on e1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

**CHECKPOINT**

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Knight on d3. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

**CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES**

A familiar pattern is insufficient if the knight can be captured. Verify protection and every legal king move.

**WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES**

A knight can check a king surrounded by its own pieces. Those pieces become a cage because a knight check cannot be blocked.

**HOW TO LOOK**

Trace the knight's route to the checking square and identify the enemy pieces that deny the king its escape squares.

The defending king is on e1. Geometrically undefended: rook on h1. Check for tactical protection.